DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE
Headquarters U.S Air Force
Washington DC 20330-1030

CFETP16F/16Z
Part I
14 September 2026

AFSC 16F/16Z

FOREIGN AREA OFFICER



CAREER FIELD EDUCATION AND TRAINING PLAN

ACCESSIBILITY: Publications and forms are available on the e-publishing website at www.e-publishing.af.mil for downloading or ordering.

RELEASABILITY: There are no releasability restrictions on this publication.

CAREER FIELD EDUCATION AND TRAINING PLAN
FOREIGN AREA OFFICER
AFSC 16FX

Table of Contents

Preface 3

Abbreviations and Terms 3

Section A – General Information 6

Section B – Air Force FAO Career Field Overview 7

Section C – FAO Training and Education Requirements 9

Section D – FAO Career Development 15

OPR: SAF/IA
Certified By: Col Rosalie Duarte, 16F/16X Air Force Career Field Manager
Pages: 24

CAREER FIELD EDUCATION AND TRAINING PLAN
FOREIGN AREA OFFICER
AFSC 16FX

Preface

1. The Career Field Education and Training Plan (CFETP) is guided by the Department of the Air Force Instruction (DAFI) 36-2670, *Total Force Development*. This officer CFETP is a comprehensive document that identifies life-cycle development requirements and support resources for the 16F Foreign Area Officer (FAO) career field. The CFETP provides a clear development pathway to instill rigor in all aspects of FAO education and training.

1.1. This document references the FAO Air Force Specialty (AFS) of 16F which applies to both 16F and 16Z core flags, as well as the 16F secondary and tertiary AFSCs still held by Air Reserve Component (ARC) FAOs.

1.1.1. All Regular Air Force (RegAF) core FAOs will have 16FXX as their primary Air Force Specialty Code (AFSC) upon certification. For ARC FAOs, Air National Guard (ANG) FAOs can only hold the 16FXX as a secondary or tertiary AFSC, while Air Force Reserve (AFR) FAOs will have the option to hold 16FXX as a core or secondary or tertiary AFSC.

1.1.2. RegAF Rated FAOs are identified with the core flag 16Z in order to retain rated status, tracking, and accountability. The 16Z core maintains aviation qualifications and is subject to all instruction and guidance pertinent to 16F and will retain 16FXX as their primary AFSC.

1.2. FAOs in Training (FIT) are designated with the 92F0 student status AFSC until completion of the FAO training pipeline per the Air Force Officer Classification Directory (AFOCD).

2. This CFETP is used by officers, supervisors, and commanders: To plan, organize, and guide FAO force development and overall management of the career field. Additionally, the plan assists FAOs in responsibly managing their own careers.

2.1. Section A provides general information about the CFETP. Section B describes the Air Force FAO program and career field, to include Department of War (DoW) guidance, a description of what FAOs do and where they work, FAO accession methods, and details on Rated FAOs Section C contains the training and education requirements associated with initial skills development and FAO Certification. Section D details FAO career progression, to include continuing education and skills sustainment training opportunities. Finally, Section E is dedicated to defining abbreviations and terms found throughout this CFETP.

Abbreviations and Terms

Advanced Academic Degree (AAD). A master's degree, Ph.D., or equivalent formal education.

Air Force Culture and Language Center (AFCLC). AFCLC creates and executes language, region, and cultural learning programs for Total Force Airmen, and provides the Service with the subject matter expertise required to institutionalize these efforts. AFCLC develops and provides country-specific culture guides, certified culture courses, and regionally specific videos via an app accessible on Apple and Google Play.

Air Force Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture (AF LREC) Office (AF/A1DG). Office of primary responsibility (OPR) for the development, coordination, and implementation of AF LREC programs and policy. Implements policy and provides guidance on the execution of Foreign Language Proficiency Bonus (FLPB). Hosts the Air Force Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture Division (AFCLC) as determined by the charter or as required by significant events. Advocates for language requirements in existing, new or potential Language Designated Positions (LDP). Coordinates with AETC to ensure LREC programs have sufficient resources through the Air Force Corporate Structure and Program Objective Memorandum (POM). Maintains the charter for the AFCLC; ensures that AFCLC has sufficient financial and manpower resources through existing Air Force corporate programming and budgeting processes to effectively execute its missions.

Career Field Manager (CFM). OPR appointed to ensure assigned Air Force Specialties/Space Force Specialties are trained and utilized to support Air Force or Space Force mission requirements. RegAF CFM works in concert with MAJCOM/FLDCOM, forward operating agencies, direct reporting units, as well as ANG, and AFR CFMs, as required per DAFI 36-2110, *Total Force Assignments*.

Competency. Attribute an individual possesses to successfully and consistently perform a given task, under specified conditions, or meeting a defined standard of performance. This enables Airmen to perform their jobs and contribute to the overall success of the Air Force. Competencies influence human performance and have a subsequent impact on mission and organizational success.

Constructive Credit Waiver (CCW). A waiver for an AAD based on equivalent duty experience.

Continuum of Learning (CoL). The career-long span of professional experience, academic education, and additional formal training designed to deliberately integrate developmental opportunities through a common taxonomy to produce adaptable, knowledge-enabled Airmen for today and tomorrow.

Council Of Colonels (CoC). A dedicated group of three O-6 FAOs (or GS-15 equivalents) per geographic region, with the mission to mentor and advocate for their respective AOR's FAOs to the RegAF Career Field Manager, Development Team, and assignment teams, with the intention to place the right person in the right position at the right time (i.e. talent management).

Defense Language Aptitude Battery (DLAB). A test that evaluates an individual's ability to complete formal courses in foreign language training.

Defense Language Institute Foreign Language Center (DLIFLC). DLIFLC is a multi-service school, under Army Training and Doctrine Command, for active and reserve components, foreign military students, and civilian personnel working in the federal government that provides resident language instruction at the Presidio of Monterey and through distance learning. Additionally, the DLI-Washington office, situated in Arlington, Virginia, is a satellite office for DLIFLC headquartered in Monterey. This office has three primary functions: Administer the Contract Foreign Language Training Program (CFLTP), providing full-time resident instruction for low enrollment languages for all Defense Attaché

Service (DAS) personnel, Security Cooperation Officers, and for other language training requirements which cannot be met through regularly scheduled courses at DLIFLC at the Presidio of Monterey.

Defense Language Proficiency Test (DLPT). A battery of foreign language tests produced by the Defense Language Institute and used by DoW. The tests evaluate general language proficiency in a foreign language in the skills of reading and listening.

Force Development. A deliberate process of preparing Airmen through the CoL with the required competencies to meet the challenges of current and future operating environments. Institutional and joint development generally results in leadership, management, and warrior ethos proficiency. Occupational development generally results in technical skill proficiency.

FAO Fellowship. An Air Force developmental education (DE) program that results in Intermediate Developmental (IDE) deliberate development in-residence credit for FAOs accessed through Traditional Development (TD).

FAO Functional Manager (FM). The senior Air Force FAO or representative at each Air Force regional component who, representing the commander, Air Force forces, supports and assists the FAO CFM, as per DAFI 36-2670, *Total Force Development*.

FAO Enabled Tour (FET). Assignments outside the FAO career field. Will be assigned when deemed beneficial to the FAO community and the officer's development (per AFI 16-109).

FAO in Training (FIT). A FAO candidate selected for development with deliberate intent for certification.

FAO Screening and Selection (FAOSS). The process through which FAO candidates voluntarily apply and are assessed for selection.

In-Region Training (IRT). Regional training conducted primarily overseas that enables FITs to meet the DoW regional experience requirement.

Interagency Language Roundtable (ILR). The ILR is a non-funded federal interagency organization established for the coordination and sharing of information about language-related activities at the federal level. The ILR language skill level descriptions are used by all USG agencies to measure language proficiency.

Intermediate Developmental Education (IDE). Specific educational opportunities including (but not limited to) Air Command and Staff College, U.S. Army Command and General Staff College, College of Naval Command and Staff, Marine Corps Command and Staff College, USAF Academy Air Officer Commanding Master's Program, Air Force Institute of Technology, and other identified AAD programs generally offered at the O-4 level of professional development.

Language Proficiency. A continuum, from memorized proficiency to functionally native proficiency, which describes the ability of an individual to function in the reading, listening, and speaking modalities of a foreign language as assessed by the USG ILR proficiency rating scale.

Language Enabled Airman Program (LEAP). An AFCLC-managed program open to officer and enlisted Airmen in most career fields. LEAP competitively selects and deliberately develops service members across the General Purpose Force (GPF) with working-level foreign language proficiency. LEAP has served as an effective means for preparing officers for FAO selection through language and in-region training provided through immersions and live online courses.

Political-Military Affairs Strategist (PAS). The PAS (16P) AFSC has slight differences in utilization and development between the RegAF and ARC. In the current RegAF construct, PAS service is intended as a one-time, career-broadening assignment that exposes officers to political-military affairs and typically begins in conjunction with IDE. Selected officers acquire a broad knowledge of political-military affairs through IDE and subsequently serve in one developmental assignment to gain political-military experience. ARC officers may also be selected as a PAS through IDE or another authorized certification method. The AFR and ANG CFMs may also direct hire officers into 16P billets who otherwise meet the requirements to become a PAS as outlined in the AFOCD and AFI 16-109.

Security Cooperation Workforce (SCW) Program. A program intended to develop and manage a professional civilian and military workforce to assess, plan, administer, execute, oversee, and evaluate DoW security cooperation (which includes security assistance (SA) programs and activities in an effective, efficient, and strategy-driven manner).

Senior Developmental Education (SDE). Specific educational opportunities to include (but not limited to) Air War College, Army War College, Naval War College, National War College, Dwight D. Eisenhower School for National Security & Resource Strategy, Harvard National Security Fellowship, Secretary of Defense Corporate Fellowship, Joint Advanced Warfighting School, and College of International Security Affairs, generally at the O-5 level of professional development.

Skills Enhancement. A generic term, frequently used in connection with language training, which involves increasing foreign language skills.

Skills Sustainment. A generic term, frequently used in connection with language training, which involves refresher, remedial, and maintenance training to prevent loss of foreign language skills.

Utilization and Training Workshop (U&TW). A preparatory forum led by the CFM and AETC/A3 training pipeline manager, attended by MAJCOM functional managers (who are the focal point for career field education and training within each MAJCOM), subject matter experts, and any AETC training development personnel that establish career field training requirements. The FAO U&TW includes advisors from AFCLC, AF/A1D- Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture (LREC), and the Reserve and Guard advisors to the Deputy Under Secretary of the Air Force for International Affairs.

Section A – General Information

3. Purpose of the CFETP. The purpose of this CFETP is to clearly define the Career Field Manager's (CFM) training and education requirements for both initial and advanced skills development and sustainment, in accordance with DoW requirements as outlined in DoDI 1315.20. The requirements outlined in this plan offer the opportunity to inform follow-on efforts to organize, train, and equip the career field with adequate resources (e.g. manpower, funding, and facilities).

3.1. The outcome of this development plan is to produce and retain skilled FAOs capable of advancing U.S. government (USG) security interests and supporting joint operations as military diplomats at the interface between the DoW, Department of State (DoS), other governmental agencies, and allies and partner nations.

3.2. Commanders, supervisors, and senior FAOs, to include the RegAF FAO Council of Colonels (CoC), must take an active role in an officer's professional development by providing mentoring and career planning.

3.2.1. FAOs should review career goals with their supervisor, commander, and/or their regional CoC during mentoring and performance feedback sessions, referencing tools such as the FAO Career Field Pyramid in Figure 1, and Department of the Air Force Manual (DAFMAN) 36-2643, *Coaching and Mentoring Program*. FAOs should discuss opportunities with mentors, their respective CoC, and/or other senior FAOs to broaden their career experience and will be expected to maintain their language skills and regional knowledge.

3.3. The FAO CFETP applies to all Air Force FAOs, regardless of component. Implementation of this plan is managed collaboratively by the CFMs (RegAF, AFR, ANG), Air Education and Training Command Operations (AETC/A3), Secretary of the Air Force's International Affairs (SAF/IA) and its Airman and Guardian Division (SAF/IAPA), and the Air Force Culture and Language Center (AFCLC).

3.4. Coordination and Approval. The RegAF FAO CFM (SAF/IAPA) is the approval authority for this CFETP. The Director of Force Development, Deputy Chief of Staff, Manpower, Personnel and Services (AF/A1D) serves as the Air Force Senior Language Authority. AETC Future Operations Division (AETC/A3X) represents the lead MAJCOM for FAO Force Development. The RegAF FAO CFM will initiate reviews of this document every four years to ensure currency and accuracy.

Section B – Air Force FAO Career Field Overview

4. Air Force FAO Program.

4.1. The Air Force FAO program is mandated by DoD Instruction (DoDI) 1315.20, *Management of the DoD Foreign Area Officer Program*, and Air Force Instruction (AFI) 16-109, *International Affairs Specialist (IAS) Programs*.

4.1.1. FAOs provide critical competencies as regional and country experts well versed in working with other USG agencies and foreign governments and security forces. As such, the FAO corps increases the DoW awareness and understanding of human, diplomatic, military, and environmental factors in foreign theaters; advances DoW access, influence, and posture in foreign countries and theaters, and advances partner capability, capacity, interoperability, and the will to conduct operations aligned with U.S. interest, as annotated in DoDI 1315.20.

4.1.2. Air Force FAOs must have:

1) A baseline of at least seven years of operational and tactical experience in the Air Force
2) Expertise in the intersection of international and military affairs
3) Deep familiarity with the political, cultural, sociological, economic, and geographic factors of the countries and regions where regional expertise is identified

4) Professional proficiency in one or more of the dominant languages in their region of expertise, in addition to English, as annotated in DoDI 1315.20

4.2. The Air Force FAO career field is a subset of the IAS program, which is managed by SAF/IA. The International Airmen Division (SAF/IAPA) manages, executes, and administers the RegAF IAS programs on behalf of SAF/IA, and the Division Chief serves as the RegAF CFM. The ARC maintains separate programs and a separate CFM, but works in coordination with SAF/IAPA.

5. FAO Accession Methods.

5.1. The RegAF FAO program uses three methods for selecting and developing officers to become FAOs: Traditional Development (TD), Direct Crossflow (DC), and Overseas Developmental Education (ODE).

5.1.1. **Traditional Development.** The TD program provides a pathway for officers who have not yet completed one or more of the three major requirements for FAO certification (language proficiency, International Relations or similar advanced academic degree with a regional focus, and relevant regional experience). Complete FAO certification requirements can be found in section C, paragraph 7.3. of this CFETP.

5.1.1.1. TD Applicants. Non-rated line officers are eligible to apply between 7-10 years of commissioned service and Rated officers are eligible after the second flying gate, at approximately 10-12 years of commissioned service. Interested and eligible line officers apply through MyVector, in accordance with the annual FAO Screening and Selection (FAOSS) Personnel Services Delivery Memorandum (PSDM) which can be found on myFSS.

5.1.2. **Direct Crossflow.** DC is a FAO accession option for RegAF and ARC officers who possess all DoW requirements, as identified in section 4.1.2., to be certified as a FAO.

5.1.2.1. DC Applicants (RegAF). There is no specific eligibility window for RegAF DC applicants. Interested and eligible line officers apply through MyVector, in accordance with the annual FAOSS PSDM which can be found on myFSS.

5.1.2.2. DC Applicants (ARC). ARC FAOs are only assessed through DC. ARC DC applications are accepted on a rolling basis and processed in order of receipt by the applicable ARC IAS team. Some training discussed in this CFETP is not yet available to the ARC and ARC members can only participate to the extent the training is made available to the ARC. Contact the applicable ARC IAS program office for more details. AFR IAS can be contacted at SAF.IAAFR.IASProgram@us.af.mil and ANG IAS can be contacted at NGB.A310T.InternationalAffairs@us.af.mil.

5.1.3. **Overseas Developmental Education (ODE) Program.** ODE is a FAO accession option for RegAF officers only. ODE program officers are selected to attend specifically designated foreign Intermediate Developmental Education (IDE) schools, typically during the Spring FAO Development Team (DT), and matched in accordance with the Air Force Developmental Education (DE) Program. Officers accessed through the ODE program must be in their IDE eligibility window. Current ODE schools are managed by the Air Force DE Program. More details on the application process and eligibility are in the annual Program Description Guide (PDG) which can be found on myFSS.

5.1.3.1. While ODE is not an Advanced Academic Degree (AAD) program, the Air Force recognizes these international Professional Military Education (PME) programs as equivalent work experience to justify a Constructive Credit Waiver (CCW) for the AAD requirement for FAO certification.

5.1.3.2. Prior to attending ODE PME, candidates must demonstrate a minimum required language proficiency for that specific program. Following completion of ODE PME, graduates are expected to demonstrate continued language proficiency IAW DoDI 1315.20 standards.

5.1.3.3. Because ODE alone doesn't fulfill IDE-equivalency requirements, ODE students must obtain Joint Professional Military Education (JPME) I credit. This is best accomplished by completing Air Command and Staff College (ACSC) through distance learning (ACSC-DL) during their IDE eligibility window.

5.2. FAO Selection. Selections of RegAF TD and DC applicants are made through FAOSS Board, an annual competitive board process, which typically occurs during the Spring FAO DT. For the ARC accession method, interested applicants can contact SAF.IAAFR.IASProgram@us.af.mil.

6. Rated FAOs (RegAF).

6.1. Rated FAOs (16Z) will typically crossflow after the second flying gate is complete (120 gate months) and will require careful career management to maintain rated status and benefits while progressing in the FAO career field. Crossflows before the second flying gate are rarely approved to prevent interruptions in Aviation Incentive Pay (AvIP) and Aviation Bonus (AvB) due to the small number of C-12 positions or other potential rated assignments.

6.2. AvIP and AvB for Rated FAOs will continue based on DoDI 7730.67, *Aviation Incentive Pays and Bonus Program* with the following considerations for FAOs:

6.2.1. A FAO training pipeline entailing 180 days or longer is considered PME that qualifies for continuous AvIP and AvB.

6.2.2. Approximately 75% of RegAF FAO assignments are on the Joint Duty Assignment List (JDAL) and qualify for continuous AvIP and AvB.

6.2.3. Rated FAO assignments (API-8, API-4, or API-3) qualify for continuous AvIP and AvB.

6.2.4. Rated FAOs outside of the assignments above will be entitled to AvIP and AvB for 48 months, after which flight pay will cease until one of the conditions above are met to resume AvIP and AvB. Eligibility for continuous AvIP also depends on meeting the required Operational Flying Duty Accumulator (OFDA) gates and maintaining medical qualification.

6.3. Aviation Bonuses. AvB is governed by DoDI 7730.67 and AFMAN 36-3004, *Aviation Bonus Program*. As long as FAOs retain their eligibility for AvIP, previously accepted retention bonuses will continue based on the agreement made at the time of signing. FAO qualification for new bonuses will be dependent on 16Z status in future fiscal year AvB programs, as with each AFSC.

Section C – FAO Training and Education Requirements

7. Initial Skills, Training, and Education

7.1. The foundational training and education requirements for a FAO are intended to transform a member from a technical expert in their original career field into a regionally focused political-military advisor. The objective is to produce an officer who possesses the necessary language and cultural fluency to provide a critical air, space, and cyberspace perspective within interagency and international settings. At this stage, the member is acquiring and honing the knowledge and skills to master the intricate socio-politico-economic landscapes of their assigned regions within a joint-combined-interagency strategic warfighting mindset that allows them to advise and assist senior civil and military leaders at the flag/general officer levels and higher. All three accession methods require region-specific education and/or training. Upon completion of initial training and necessary requirements, the (RegAF) officer will be certified as a FAO. ARC FAOs are certified upon acceptance by the DC Board but are not considered qualified until completion of the Joint Foreign Area Officer Course (JFAOC I).

7.2. **FAO Certification Process (RegAF and ARC).** SAF/IAPA retains sole RegAF FAO certification authority and will award FAO certification letters once all requirements have been fulfilled. ARC officers are certified by their respective ARC IAS program office. Per DoDI 1315.20 and AFI 16-109, the requirements for AF FAO certification (16F1X/16Z) include the following:

1) Advanced Academic Degree (AAD) with a regional focus
2) Foreign Language Proficiency in the region of specialization
3) In-Region Training (IRT) in the region of specialization
4) Joint FAO Course Phase I (JFAOC-I) (ARC members can only attend after certification)
5) U.S. Air Force FAO Orientation Course (ARC attendance is optional after certification)

7.3. **FAO Certification Requirements**.

1) **Advanced Academic Degree (AAD).** Completion of an AAD program in international relations, or a similar field, with a regional focus of at least twelve credit hours, is required for all accession methods
    a) TD and DC
        i) RegAF officers who already have an International Relations or International Affairs AAD, but lack courses with the relevant regional focus; or who have sufficient experience for a CCW of the advanced degree, will attend a 12-credit in-residence regional certification program (see AFI 16-109 International Affairs Specialist Program for further details)
    b) ODE
        i) Completion of the foreign ODE program
        ii) While ODE is not an AAD program, the Air Force recognizes these foreign PME programs as equivalent work experience to justify a CCW for the AAD requirement for FAO certification
    c) ARC
        i) ARC members are required to have an AAD prior to being approved into the FAO program, as determined by the AFR IAS and ANG IAS program offices, unless they meet the requirements for CCW

2) **Foreign Language Proficiency (TD/DC/ODE/ARC)** per DoDI 1315.20 requirements.
    a) Completion of language testing in all three modalities (listening/reading/speaking) per DoDI 1315.20 Defense Language Proficiency Test/Oral Proficiency Interview (DLPT/OPI) scoring requirements

b) (RegAF) SAF/IAPA will assign each FAO selectee with a regional target language. If the officer does not meet DoDI 1315.20 language proficiency requirements in their assigned target language, that officer will attend language training at the Defense Language Institute (DLI), or another program tailored to their needs in order to attain a minimum score of 2/2/1+ on the Interagency Language Roundtable (ILR) Scale. AFR FAOs will not be approved to attend DLI for remediation. It will be the AFR FAO's responsibility to maintain proficiency through free resources offered by AFCLC, or other methods chosen by the member themselves. AFR FAOs will be decertified after six months of not meeting the DoDI standards

c) Accessed officers with existing proficiency in their target language may be able to forego the language training portion of their RegAF FAO certification process, if deemed appropriate by SAF/IAPA

3) **In-Region Training (IRT).** In accordance with DoDI 1315.20, para 2.8.b.3.(b), FAOs in training are required to complete at least 180 days in the region of specialization. This training involves significant interaction with host-nation personnel and host-nation entities in the regions in which the FAO specializes. Before beginning the IRT, FAO candidates must complete the two-week FAO Fundamentals Course (online) and six-hour Steady State Planning (S2) Course (online).
   a) IRT Requirements (TD). IRT is comprised of 180 days in the target region of specialization. CFM retains the right to waive all or part of IRT requirement. IRT generally includes:
      i) Up to 90 days of Strategic Engagement (SE) activities. Ideally, SE should include activities with more than one embassy country team, as well as with either Combatant Command J5 (CCMD) or the component Air Force A5
      ii) Up to 90 days in an in-country language-culture (LC) immersion program. May include homestay, if available
   b) IRT Requirements (ODE). Completion of 60 days of regional training focused on Strategic Engagement (SE). ODE graduates are exempt from the IRT requirement for language and culture immersion
   c) IRT Requirements (DC). N/A
   d) IRT Requirements (ARC). A minimum of 180 days experience in the region of expertise is required prior to application submission. Civilian experience may be considered on a case-by-case basis

4) **Joint FAO Course (JFAOC) Phase I (TD/DC/ODE/ARC)**. Completion of the one-week in-residence course, hosted by Defense Language Institute (DLI) Foreign Language Center at the Presidio of Monterey, California, is required
   a) The course provides an understanding of joint FAO responsibilities for force development, career management, and specific duties

5) **USAF FAO Orientation Course (TD/DC/ODE/ARC)**. Attendance at the multi-day USAF-specific in-residence course conducted by SAF/IAPA and AETC A3X is required. This course is designed for the newly selected FAO cohort with the intent of introducing officers to the FAO career field
   a) DC only. USAF FAO Orientation Course may be waived by SAF/IAPA on a case-by-case basis
   b) ARC attendance is not required unless otherwise directed by the applicable ARC IAS CFM

7.4. **FAO Decertification (RegAF and ARC)**. The FAO CFMs retain sole decertification authority in cases of gross misconduct, failure to maintain certification standards, or other violations of U.S. military regulations and laws, as well as international laws.

7.5. **FAO Fellowship (RegAF).**

7.5.1. Only officers selected into the FAO career field via TD are eligible for the FAO Fellowship in-residence IDE program. This fellowship is not applicable to officers who crossflowed to FAO career field via DC or ODE. More information on FAO Fellowship can be found on the SAF/IA FAO Intelink site.

7.5.2. **FAO Fellowship Requirements.** In addition to basic FAO Certification requirements outlined in section C, paragraph 7, FAOs must complete Air Command and Staff College Distance Learning (ACSC-DL) at Air University (AU), or an equivalent PME program during the officer's IDE eligibility window.

7.5.2.1. ACSC-DL Requirement.

1) Once eligible for ACSC-DL generally after selection to O-4/Major), FAO Fellowship officers should self-enroll in ACSC-DL on the AU website: https://www.airuniversity.af.edu/GCPME/ACSC
2) Completion of ACSC-DL results in Joint Professional Military Education (JPME) Phase I credit which is a requirement for the FAO Fellowship IDE in-residence program

7.6. **FAO Training Plan** (**RegAF**). Since each officer begins the initial FAO training pipeline with different skills and experiences, AETC will issue officers an individualized training and education plan to achieve a standardized level of initial skills and competencies. These tailored plans will reflect appropriate credit and/or waiver for past training, education, and experience.

7.6.1. Training Plan Credits and/or Waivers. FAOs in training can receive credit toward or a waiver from certain aspects of the training plan. SAF/IAPA is the approving authority for Air Force FAO training plans. Waivers/credits can include, but are not limited to:

7.6.1.1. In-region experience involving significant interaction with host-nation nationals and/or host-nation entities in the foreign countries or regions in which they specialize. Significant interaction entails working directly with host-nation entities (such as professional development education abroad or duty as a military exchange officer). Emphasis will be given to in-region experiences within the embassy environment for a greater understanding of U.S. diplomacy, Security Cooperation (SC), and Security Assistance (SA) interests and processes.

7.6.1.2. Language skills will be assessed via the DLPT and OPI in the modalities of reading, listening, and speaking.

7.6.1.3. Advanced Academic degree (AAD) in international relations, or equivalent, with a regional focus (typically 12 credit hours). Trainees who possess an AAD in international relations, or equivalent, without a regional focus will still be programed for a regional certification. Constructive Credit Waiver (CCW) in lieu of AAD may be granted for specific assignments, such as Embassy/country team, Military Personnel Exchange Program (MPEP), and the Olmsted Scholarship.

7.6.2. Language Training Locations. Defense Language Institute Foreign Language Center (DLIFLC), Monterey, California is the primary provider of initial in-residence language training for FAOs. Other options for language training, which will be decided for each candidate by AETC when putting together a training plan, include:

1) DLI-Washington
2) Non-DLI contracted commercial vendors
3) Other USG language programs

7.6.3. Permanent Change of Station (PCS). Because it is desirable to minimize PCS during a FAO's initial training pipeline, language training and the AAD or regional certification will generally be collocated in one of two primary locations:

1) Monterey, California
2) National Capital Region (NCR)

8. Assignment Specific Training (RegAF and ARC).

8.1. FAOs assigned to country teams as a Security Cooperation Officer (SCO) or as an attaché will require specialized training before beginning the assignment. Details for each respective training is as follows:

8.2. **Security Cooperation Requirements.** SCO training is mandatory prior to all SCO assignments.

8.2.1. SCO training is managed through the Defense Security Cooperation Service (DSCS), subordinate to the Defense Security Cooperation Agency (DSCA).

8.2.2. Prior to the first SCO assignment, FAOs are required to complete the online Foundations of Security Cooperation Course and the in-person Security Cooperation Organization (SCO) Qualification Course. The SCO Qualification Course consists of approximately eight weeks of full-time training (minus weekends/federal holidays) at Defense Security Cooperation University (DSCU) Headquarters in the NCR and is the primary training course for those personnel on assignment to SCOs. The course provides crucial, foundational knowledge for executing SC activities with our allies and partners to meet national security objectives.

8.2.3. Senior FAOs (O5s-O6s) officially assigned to Key SC-identified Expert Level positions at U.S. embassy-based SCOs overseas – e.g., Senior Defense Officials/Defense Attachés (SDO/DATTs), SCO Chiefs, Deputy SCO Chiefs, or Program Managers – are eligible for the SCO Refresher Course if they have already served in a SCO. This is an abridged 2-week course that equips FAOs to manage applicable SC and SA programs at the country and regional level and renew knowledge and expand on the latest advances in SC policy, integration and planning procedures. Enrollment in this course is subject to DSCS review and approval.

8.2.4. SCO Spouse Course. The SCO Spouse Course is designed for spouses of FAOs assigned to security cooperation positions in U.S. Embassies. This hybrid course includes both virtual and resident phases and is held four times each fiscal year, with funded travel for SCO spouses to attend the in-residence week held in the NCR.

8.3. **Attaché Requirements.** There are a number of requirements preceding an attaché assignment.

8.3.1. **Screening**. A higher-level security clearance adjudication, a SAF/IAPA screening panel in which the candidate (and spouse if applicable) is interviewed for compatibility, along with a counterintelligence (CI) polygraph as mandated by the Defense Intelligence Agency (DIA), are required for all incoming attaché designates. For RegAF FAOs, SAF/IAPA Attaché/SCO Branch will coordinate screening requirements with DIA.

8.3.2. SAF/IA AFR IAS coordinates with DIA and Headquarters Individual Reservist Readiness Integration Organization (HQ RIO) for all AFR attaché billets. ANG does not have attaché assignments.

8.3.3. Joint Military Attaché School (JMAS). Once initial security requirements are fulfilled (including the granting of the TS/SCI clearance, CI polygraph passed, and being cleared by the SAF/IAPA screening panel members), attaché designates are required to attend and pass the 13-week JMAS course taught at Joint Base Anacostia-Bolling (JBAB) in Washington, D.C. After the completion of JMAS (and any further language training required), the attaché designate will receive a Training Report (TR). Reserve attachés can also attend the full 13-week JMAS program, pending space and billet allocation.

8.3.3.1. JMAS Spouse Training Program. In parallel with the attaché course, DIA sponsors an optional Spouse Training Program (STP). JMAS and STP take place three times per year (January, April, August).

8.3.4. DIA Reserve Support Course (RSC) (AFR). This DIA sponsored course, known as the Reserve Support Course, is a requirement for all AFR FAOs assigned to an attaché billet who have not completed the full thirteen-week JMAS course. This one-week formal JMAS course is held annually in December. Following the course, Reserve attachés will be required to immediately complete one week of on-the-job training in the attaché's respective Geographic Division (GEODIV). Members may be unable to perform Military Personnel Appropriation (MPA) tours with DIA or work in a Defense Attache Office (DAO) without completion of RSC or JMAS.

8.4. **Foreign Affairs Counter Threat (FACT) Course (RegAF and ARC)**. This five-day course is required for all FAOs assigned to a country team or for FAOs traveling in temporary duty status (TDY) in excess of 90 days under Chief of Mission (COM) authority (Note: ARC Military Personnel Appropriation (MPA) orders also fall under this requirement). FACT is also required for any accompanying spouses seeking employment at the U.S. Embassy. It is optional for all other spouses accompanying the FAO on their country team tour. FACT provides participants with the knowledge and skills necessary to live and work in critical and high threat environments overseas. Further specialized training is required for those assigned to specific high-threat posts.

8.5. **C-12 Aircraft Qualification Course (AQC) (RegAF 16Z only).** ACQ is a comprehensive six-week program designed to qualify fixed-wing Air Force pilots (11 AFS) in the C-12 C/D aircraft. These aircraft are flown by SCO and attaché pilots stationed at specific embassies. The six-week course is divided into three phases, which include:

1) Ground Training: Conducted over three weeks in Dothan, Alabama, this phase covers fundamental aircraft systems and flight operations, incorporating simulator sessions to build essential skills
2) Flight Training: Conducted over approximately two weeks at Edwards Air Force Base, California, and focuses on practical flying skills, culminating in a formal flight evaluation

3) Top Off Training: The final week takes place at Andrews Air Force Base, where students train with DIA pilots, focusing on short and austere field operations

Section D – FAO Career Development

9. FAO Career Development Overview. FAO assignments and continued training are essential for creating well-rounded officers, building their depth of knowledge, language skills, and strategic acumen to ensure they remain prepared for the demands of the global security environment.

9.1. **FAO Assignments (RegAF).** While on assignment, a FAO executes the DoW mission in support of U.S. national security objectives, while also deepening FAO competencies. As the officer advances in rank, assignments should be selected that provide additional breadth of experience in preparation for greater responsibilities. Assignment opportunities vary by region of specialty and component and may not be equally distributed.

9.1.1. Categories of FAO Assignments. Following initial skills development, FAO assignments generally fall into the following categories (note that this is not an all-inclusive listing):

1) U.S. Embassy (country team)
    a) Attaché (SDO/DATT, AIRA, A/AIRA)
    b) SCO
2) Joint staff
    a) Joint Chief of Staff/Office of Secretary of Defense
    b) Geographic Combatant Command
3) Air Force institutional staff
    a) SAF/IA
    b) HAF/A5
    c) Air Force component to a geographic combatant command
4) Interagency
    a) Defense Agency (e.g., Defense Intelligence Agency, Missile Defense Agency, Defense Threat Reduction Agency, Defense Security Cooperation Agency, NATO, etc.)
    b) Department of State
    c) The White House
5) Other organizations
    a) Mobility Support Advisory Squadron
    b) Inter-American Air Force Academy (IAAFA)
    c) Various training organizations

9.1.2. First Assignment. A FAO's first assignment is influenced by a range of factors, including the timing of available positions, individual qualifications and requirements, and broader Air Force needs. While a country team assignment is often a top preference, FAOs must remain open to opportunities across the enterprise, including staff and CCMD positions. All FAO-coded billets enable FAOs to apply their regional education, language skills, and cultural expertise in support of their designated area of focus.

9.1.3. Subsequent Assignments. To become a well-rounded FAO and have the best chances at career progression, an officer is expected to serve in both country team and staff positions. As a FAO progresses in their career, serving in a different CCMD should also be considered as an opportunity for growth.

Figure 1. (RegAF) FAO Career Assignment Timeline



9.2. FAO Command Opportunities (RegAF). Squadron command is important and will be viewed as career-enhancing. For the 16F career field, command experience is not a requirement for O-6 promotion, and not having command will not be considered a negative discriminator. FAO squadron command opportunities are limited to lieutenant colonels and lieutenant colonel-selects. Officers must be a certified core FAO (16F) and have completed at least 12 months (unaccompanied) or 24 months (accompanied) of continuous full-time service in a 16F or 16P billet in order to be eligible for FAO command.

9.2.1. Command opportunities at the lieutenant colonel level (subject to change):

1) CC, 332nd Training Squadron (Defense Language Institute English Language Center (DLIELC), JBSA Lackland, TX)
2) CC, 637th International Support Squadron (DLIELC, JBSA Lackland, TX)
3) CC, MPEP Americas (JB Andrews, MD)
4) CC, MPEP Europe, Middle East, Africa (Ramstein AB, Germany)
5) CC, MPEP Asia-Pacific (JB Pearl Harbor-Hickam, HI)
6) CC, NPS Air Force Element (AFELM) (Monterey, CA)
7) CC, Defense POW/MIA Accounting Agency (DPAA) Det 1, POW/MIA (Bangkok, Thailand)
8) CC, 318th Training Squadron (IAAFA, JBSA Lackland, TX)
9) CC, 837th Training Squadron (IAAFA, JBSA Lackland, TX)
10) CC, 425th Air Base Squadron (Incirlik AB, TUR)
11) CC, 717th Air Base Squadron (Ankara AB, TUR)
12) CC, 337th Air Support Squadron (Canberra, AUS)
13) CC, 2nd Intel Squadron (DIA, JBAB, DC)

9.2.2. Command opportunities at the colonel level:

1) International Officer School, Maxwell AFB, AL
2) 637th Training Group, JBSA Lackland, TX
3) IAAFA, JBSA Lackland, TX
4) Commander/Deputy Commander (rotates), 77th Intelligence Wing (IW), DIA, JBAB, Wash, D.C.

9.3. FAO Enabled Tours (FET) (RegAF). FAOs may occasionally fill assignments in their origin AFSC when FAO manning permits. FETs should be complementary to the FAO's regional and language specialization if possible and may be approved on a case-by-case basis, only in coordination with origin AFSC assignment team and SAF/IAPA.

10. FAO Competencies (RegAF and ARC).

10.1. Competencies are the combination of knowledge, skills, and abilities that manifest in an observable, measurable pattern of behaviors. Competencies influence human performance and have a subsequent impact on mission and organizational success. FAO occupational competencies were adopted in 2019 and are the foundation of the FAO career field.

10.1.1. **Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture (LREC)**. LREC proficiencies are central to success as a FAO. This competency is a key enabler when engaging with current and potential regional partners.

10.1.2. **Political-Military Affairs (PMA)**. This competency acknowledges the FAOs need to excel at the intersection of diplomatic and military activities. The PMA competency does not have a sustainment or professional development track; however, fulfilling core FAO assignments in one's career meets intent of advancement in this competency.

10.1.3. **Security Cooperation (SC)**. This competency applies to all FAOs regardless of assignment or rank. FAOs become DoW experts on SC, which includes SA. SC/SA enables partnerships between USAF and allies and partners, provides U.S. access, basing and overflight in strategic locations, and builds host nation defense capacity, with the goal to counter strategic threats through readiness. DSCU trains FAOs on SC with specific in-residence and online courses from practitioner to expert.

10.2. FAO Competency Proficiency Levels. Unlike most AFSCs, FAOs can and will rotate between diverse types of organizations with unique missions and problem sets. FAOs should seek professional development seminars, symposiums, working groups, and LREC immersions to advance competencies.

11. FAO Occupational Badge (RegAF and ARC).

11.1. **Basic Level Badge**. FAOs earn the basic badge upon completion of all Air Force FAO certification requirements and are in receipt of their FAO Certification Memorandum from SAF/IAPA, or the respective ARC IAS program office. Officers in the FAO certification process who have not fulfilled all requirements are not eligible to wear the badge. ARC officers must also complete JFAOC I prior to wear.



11.2. **Senior Level Badge**. Earned by officers after three years of FAO experience in FAO or Political-Military Affairs Strategist (PAS) coded billets.



11.3. **Master Level Badge**. Earned by officers after eight years of FAO experience in FAO or PAS coded billets.



12. FAO Core AFS. Once all FAO certification requirements have been fulfilled, the FAO core Air Force Specialty (AFS) will be awarded as either 16F (non-rated) or 16Z (rated) via a letter of certification from the FAO CFM, or designated representative. The FAO's unit of assignment will process the AFSC change using Air Force Form 2096.

12.1. All core FAOs will maintain 16FXX as a primary AFSC, to include those with the core flag of 16Z. Regional breakouts are identified using the following suffixes:

1) 16FXC, U.S. Southern Command AOR
2) 16FXD, U.S. Pacific Command AOR
3) 16FXF, U.S. Central Command AOR
4) 16FXG, U.S. Africa Command AOR
5) 16FXH, U.S. European Command AOR
6) 16FXL, Generalist (duty AFSC only, to be used for assignments to billets in which any certified FAO may serve)

12.2. **ARC FAO AFS**. ARC FAOs are awarded the secondary/tertiary AFSC upon FAO certification. AFR FAOs may later re-core to 16F/Z, as approved by the AFR IAS CFM.

12.3. **Special Experience Identifiers (SEIs).** SEIs provide a method to quickly screen the officer database for specific experience and may be used in the RegAF officer assignment process.

12.3.1. For RegAF FAOs, SEIs are awarded and SAF/IAPA enters them into FAOs' records upon certification. FAOs will be awarded one of the following:

1) JIL, accessed through Direct Crossflow
2) JIP, accessed through Traditional Development

3) JIU, accessed through Overseas Educational Programs: ODE, Mansfield Fellowship Program, and Olmsted Scholar Program

12.3.2. ARC FAOs are awarded the SEI by their respective IAS program office for submittal through their local FSS or MyFSS for record updates.

13. FAO Experience Qualifications.

13.1. Qualifications for 16F1X Basic Level. Officers designated for FAO development will be granted the entry level FAO AFSC (16F1X) upon completion of their applicable initial FAO education and training as outlined in AFI 16-109 and in section seven of this CFETP. DC FAOs will be awarded the 16F1X AFSC upon FAO certification.

13.2. Qualifications for 16F3X Qualified Level. Officers will be awarded the qualified FAO AFSC (16F3X) after successfully completing a minimum of 12 months in a FAO (16F) or PAS (16P) billet.

13.2.1. With ARC IAS CFM approval, ARC officers may earn award through FAO MPA tours, or other activated orders, or while residing in a 16P billet.

13.3. Qualifications for 16F4X Staff Level. Awarded based on position. Officers must be assigned to a staff position above Wing level for a minimum of 12 months.

13.3.1. ARC FAOs may also earn 16F4X for assignments to 16P4 billets, as determined by the ARC IAS CFM.

14. Joint Credit.

14.1. **Joint Officer Qualification**. The Goldwater-Nichols Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1986 (Goldwater-Nichols Act) codified the requirements for commissioned officers to be educated and experienced in joint matters. The Joint Qualification System (JQS) builds upon this legislation by providing a structure that recognizes the expeditionary and inherently joint nature of how military forces operate in the 21st century. The JQS provides active and reserve component officers an opportunity to earn joint qualifications upon completion of the requisite joint PME and completion of a full tour (36 months) of duty in a joint assignment (via either the standard path or the experience path). The JQS offers four levels of joint qualification. For more information, see CJCSI 1330.05, *Joint Officer Management Program Procedures.*

14.2. Approximately 75% of (RegAF) FAO positions are considered as Joint Duty Assignment List (JDAL) billets, and joint credit is automatic upon completing time on station requirements. FAOs can confirm with the organization's J1 if a billet is on the JDAL. Because of the limited nature and exclusivity, joint positions are considered controlled tours and it is generally not possible to curtail out of such assignments.

14.2.1. ARC FAOs should reach out to the respective ARC IAS program office for ARC joint credit award specifics.

14.3. If the billet is not on the JDAL, FAOs may apply for Experience-Joint Duty Assignment (E-JDA) credit, per DoDI 1300.19, *Joint Officer Management Program*. To earn E-JDA credit, the FAO must complete at least 24 months within the position of inquiry and must apply within 1 year of the tour end date. FAOs can submit a self-nomination package to the DHRA Mission Services Portal.

15. Continuing Education. Because FAOs are required to maintain certain standards with regards to their language and regional expertise, they should plan to continue their education throughout their career. Utilizing the full spectrum of educational opportunities ensures FAOs remain regional and functional experts. This section discusses three broad education opportunities that typically follow initial skills development: Professional Military Education (PME), Joint Professional Military Education (JPME), Professional Continuing Education (PCE), region specific training and continued language training.

15.1. **Annual FAO Requirements.**

15.1.1. DLPT/OPI. FAOs are required to take the DLPT annually and OPI biennially in order to maintain Foreign Language Proficiency Bonus (FLPB) and FAO standards. DAFI 36-4005, *Total Force Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture Program,* allows biennial testing for FAOs who score Interagency Language Roundtable (ILR) level of 3/3 or higher using any combination of the tested modalities, or ILR 3 for single modality pay where authorized.

15.1.2. Language, Regional Expertise and Culture (LREC). FAOs are required to accomplish between 40 and 80 hours of LREC training annually, as annotated in DoDI 1315.20, *Management of the DoD Foreign Area Officer Program*.

15.2. **Professional Military Education (PME).**

15.2.1. Intermediate Developmental Education (IDE) is an essential element of the professional development continuum for Air Force officers, specifically tailored to cultivate advanced leadership capabilities and a comprehensive understanding of strategic principles. It is imperative that FAOs complete an IDE program during their time as a major, as it is a prerequisite for promotion consideration to the rank of lieutenant colonel. IDE opportunities are primarily delivered through intermediate-level institutions. The USAF provides the Air Command and Staff College (ACSC), with options for both in-residence and distance learning, as its principal IDE program. In addition, joint educational opportunities that satisfy the IDE requirement are available at sister-service institutions, including the U.S. Army Command and General Staff College, the College of Naval Command and Staff, and the Marine Corps Command and Staff College. The IDE requirement may also be fulfilled through a variety of select fellowship programs and designated international military schools. Designated overseas IDE schools will also lead to FAO certification, as part of deliberate FAO development (see Section 5.1.3. for Overseas Development Program).

15.2.2. Senior Developmental Education (SDE). FAOs should complete SDE as a lieutenant colonel and prior to promotion consideration to colonel. SDE programs are categorized as senior-level colleges, which include each Service's war college, National Defense University (NDU) programs, other fellowships, and international schools. NDU programs include the National War College and the Eisenhower School for National Security and Resource Strategy. The Air Force offers Air War College (AWC) for SDE credit, available both in-residence and through distance learning.

15.2.2.1. ARC FAOs may complete SDE as either a lieutenant colonel or colonel but are encouraged to complete it prior to meeting the O-6 promotion board. AFR FAOs cannot compete for the Key Personnel List during the annual Development Team (DT) Board if they have not completed SDE within four years time in grade as a lieutenant colonel.

15.2.3. There are multiple international SDE programs (managed by the Overseas Developmental Education Program) that FAOs are eligible to attend. The following is a selection of available programs; this list is not exhaustive, and program availability varies from year to year.

1) Argentine Joint War College
2) Australia Defence and Strategic Studies Course
3) Bangladesh National Defence Course, National Defence College
4) Belgian Royal Military Academy - Belgian Superior Staff Course
5) Inter-American Defense College (IADC)
6) Israeli Defense Forces (IDF) National Defense College (NDC)
7) Japanese National Institute for Defense Studies Regular Course
8) Royal Jordanian National Defense College
9) Malaysian Armed Forces Defence College
10) Pakistan National Defense University National Security and War Course
11) Royal Thai Air War College

15.3. **Joint Professional Military Education (JPME).** The Goldwater-Nichols Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1987 (Goldwater-Nichols Act) requires the Department of Defense to develop and implement a program for joint education. Joint Professional Military Education (JPME) satisfies this requirement through a two-phase approach.

15.3.1. JPME Phase I. Phase I provides an introductory baseline understanding of the joint force and is often a block of instruction within the curriculum taught at Service staff colleges. It prepares officers to perform field grade responsibilities. Officers selected for IDE at non-JPME I awarding programs (e.g., FAO Fellowship/NPS, ODE) are required to complete ACSC-DL or the equivalent to receive both JPME Phase I and IDE deliberate development credit. In addition, JPME Phase I is a prerequisite for JPME Phase II.

15.3.2. JPME Phase II. JPME Phase II builds on the previous baseline by incorporating joint doctrine through the execution of the Joint Planning Process. International SDE programs do not award JPME Phase II credit. Though not a requirement, FAOs are encouraged to complete JPME Phase II program during their eligibility window to maximize their competitiveness for promotion to O-6.

15.3.2.1. Resident programs at Service war colleges and all National Defense University (NDU) programs award JPME Phase II credit.

15.3.2.2. The NDU's Joint Forces Staff College (JFSC) Joint and Combined Warfighting School is not an SDE program but offers either an in-residence or hybrid program resulting in JPME Phase II credit. FAOs can attend as a major or lieutenant colonel.

15.3.2.2.1. Since JFSC is a joint school, priority for attendance generally goes to officers enroute or currently assigned to a joint organization (e.g., Combatant Command, SCO, etc.). FAOs who receive an assignment to a Geographic Combatant Command are strongly encouraged to request attendance to JFSC from their gaining command prior to their joint assignment. If that is not possible, FAOs should inquire with their gaining unit about attending JFSC sometime after arrival.

15.4. **Professional Continuing Education (PCE).**

15.4.1. DSCU Security Cooperation Workforce (SCW) Certification. SCW Certification through DSCU is encouraged for all FAOs; however, certification is also dependent upon assignments and billets occupied. FAOs are required to complete SCW education that aligns an appropriate level of SCW certification to their level of professional experience, starting with the SCW Basic Certification, upon certification as a FAO.

15.4.2. MAJCOM/Embassy/Interagency Specific Opportunities (RegAF). Educational opportunities from MAJCOMs, embassies, and interagency organizations are considered part of a FAO's career development. Although not formal training, events such as conferences, symposiums, and key leader engagements can enhance a FAO's core competencies. SAF/IA may have limited funding available to support these opportunities. FAOs may inquire about funding availability by emailing the IAS workflow at saf.iapa.ias.program.workflow@us.af.mil.

15.5. Region-Specific Continuing Education.

15.5.1. JFAOC Phase II. The JFAOC Phase II program provides intermediate-level joint FAO professional development seminars to enhance regional expertise. These week-long, interactive seminars are focused on mid-career FAOs and conducted in coordination with the Geographic Combatant Commands. The courses also provide professional and leadership development modules aimed at preparing FAOs for assignments of increasing responsibility.

15.5.1.1. Eligibility for JFAOC II is limited to FAOs who have completed at least one FAO assignment and meet all FAO certification standards (as indicated in Section 7.3). ARC eligibility differs slightly, as determined by the applicable ARC IAS program office.

15.5.1.2. SAF/IAPA, SAF/IA AFR IAS, and ANG IAS are the approval authority for their respective applicants. JFAOC Phase II offerings are distributed by email and through the SAF/IAPA IAS Intelink or the ARC Sharepoint site. ARC attendance at JFAOC II is not required but encouraged, if approved by the respective ARC IAS CFM.

15.5.2. DoW Regional Centers. DoW regional centers align with the Geographic Combatant Commands and utilize unique academic forums to build strong, sustainable international networks of security leaders. The regional centers support defense strategy objectives and policy priorities. These centers offer executive-development strategic-security studies, research, and outreach in rigorous programs. The regional centers accomplish their mission primarily through resident and in-region programs including seminars, and courses, bilateral workshops, alumni outreach events, and research publications. The regional centers offer a great resource in support of language, region, culture and political-military affairs.

15.5.2.1. George C. Marshall European Center for Security Studies, Garmisch-Partenkirchen, Germany. The Marshall Center offers courses applicable to EUCOM and AFRICOM FAOs, including:

1) European Security Seminar – South (5 days)
2) European Security Seminar – North (5 days)
3) European Security Seminar – East (5 days)

15.5.2.2. Daniel K. Inouye Asia-Pacific Center for Security Studies, Honolulu, Hawaii. The Inouye Center offers courses and workshops applicable to INDOPACOM FAOs, including the five-day Asia-Pacific Orientation Course

15.5.2.3. William J. Perry Center for Hemispheric Defense Studies, Fort McNair, Washington, D.C. The Perry Center offers courses and regional seminars applicable to SOUTHCOM FAOs.

15.5.2.4. Africa Center for Strategic Studies, Fort McNair, Washington, D.C. The Africa Center offers academic programs applicable to AFRICOM FAOs.

15.5.2.5. Near East-South Asia Center for Strategic Studies, Fort McNair, Washington, D.C. The Near East-South Asia Center offers several seminars and programs applicable to CENTCOM and INDOPACOM FAOs.

15.6. **Continued Language Training.** FAOs are required to maintain language proficiency as a career-long commitment. It is important for each FAO to document language enhancement activities and training throughout their career. FAOs are expected to complete a minimum of 40 hours of LREC sustainment training annually as part of their normal duties. Language sustainment is provided by select universities and online language programs. Resources can be found on the IAS Intelink site.

15.6.1. Other Language Enhancement Opportunities. An extensive and current list of both funded and no-cost FAO language learning opportunities can be found at the IAS Intelink site.

15.6.2. Language Enabled Development Resource (LEaDeR). LEaDeR is a training management and file sharing system used by AFCLC and SAF/IAPA, which stores FAOs' language scores, immersion, in-region training, and education records. FAOs can also check eMentor availability via LEaDeR and are encouraged to use the system's networking capability.

15.7. Other Training Resources. Of note, participation for any training is subject to approval and funding by SAF/IAPA or the applicable ARC IAS program office.

15.7.1. USAF Special Operations School (USAFSOS). Located at Hurlburt Field, Fl, USAFSOS provides training to turn skilled Airmen into special operators. Currently, courses are focused on four areas: asymmetric warfare education, regional and cultural awareness, special operations forces (SOF) professional development, and joint operations. The regional and cultural awareness courses are geared to SOF areas of responsibility and orient the SOF warrior to the cultural, historical, political, economic, and security issues of a particular region. For FAOs, these space-available courses can enhance regional expertise.

15.7.1.1. USAFSOS course offerings of particular interest to FAOs include:

1) AFRICOM Theater Course
2) CENTCOM Theater Course
3) EUCOM Theater Course
4) INDOPACOM Theater Course
5) SOUTHCOM Theater Course
6) Dynamics of International Terrorism
7) Building Partnership Aviation Capacity Seminar
8) Interagency Orientation Course
9) Intercultural Competencies Basic Course

10) Intercultural Competencies Course

15.7.2. Foreign Service Institute (FSI). FSI functions as the United States government's primary training provider for foreign affairs personnel, serving the DoS and the broader foreign affairs community. Its purpose is to offer the ongoing educational opportunities necessary for success in the international arena. FSI provides over 800 courses, with nearly 600 delivered on campus and 275 available through distance learning platforms. Annually, these programs see approximately 170,000 enrollments. The offerings from FSI are designed to improve the language, regional, and cultural competencies of FAOs, in addition to their political-military skills.

15.7.3. The School of Professional and Area Studies (SPAS). SPAS provides job-specific orientation and area studies training to empower foreign affairs professionals to advance U.S. interests and tackle the evolving challenges of 21st-century diplomacy.

15.7.4. U.S. Air Force Expeditionary Center (USAFEC) Force Protection (FP) Training. In addition to the FACT course attended by attachés and SCOs, USAFEC offers the following FP courses:

1) Field Craft Uncertain
2) Field Craft Hostile

15.7.5. Introduction to Space. Space 100 is a fundamental space education course taught by the National Security Space Institute at the unclassified level. This course provides an introductory educational level of space systems and how they are used to support global Joint military operations. FAOs are eligible to sign up for a seven week distance learning course at https://nssi.spaceforce.mil/?directlink&nav-home/courses/space100&&&&&&&&.

16. Conclusion. The FAO career field is defined by its unparalleled and unique experiences, allowing these Airmen to represent the both the Department of the Air Force and the Department of War around the globe, and provide direct contributions to national security. Consequently, it demands a commitment to lifelong growth, with comprehensive training and sustained language proficiency as cornerstones. This document anticipates the demanding nature of a FAO's career and attempts to guide the FAO toward success through these cornerstones.